

WITH ABFRL'S BACKING, the designer is busy strengthening the brand. "We are going to use our core—which is wedding couture—for storytelling, to be able to create different-tiered products at different prices to be able to engage our customers who will slowly and steadily find a ladder to climb up to the core." However, he plans to make wedding couture very limited and very exclusive. He has already started creating guardrails. Bollywood partnerships have reduced significantly and he is no longer giving his creations for the red carpet. In today's age of social media, Mukherjee says that everyone believes that they are a celebrity. "For us, our customers are our celebrities. And we are trying to create something that is unique for them. And that's something that's not made very visible. But what we are going to make democratically visible are our entry-level products; once we get into beauty that is going to be the most widely distributed. And then it's going to be accessories."

Mukherjee says that Indian clothing, which is the heart and soul of the brand, will become more and more exclusive. In clothing, the focus will be on western ready-to-wear. However, that too will be of the best quality. For instance, ready-to-wear starts at ₹35,000 for a silk shirt with an original artwork, digitally printed. "We are

very mindful that we will never dilute the core," he says.

While currently it is wedding couture that contributes the maximum to revenues, he expects jewellery to surpass that over the next few years. Mukherjee launched his jewellery collection in 2017 and while it was a natural fit, he had an interesting reason for doing so. "When I started looking at people's selfies, I realised that we occupy the smallest real estate. You see a little bit of the blouse in a wedding picture, you see the garland, the make-up and the jewellery. Where are the clothes? Nowhere. And if the bride decides to wear a bikini blouse, then God save us," he laughs. "So that's when I realised that I want more real estate in that picture. And, for me, it was a logical move to start getting into beauty which we'll eventually get into, and to get into jewellery."

Accessories is another category he is focussing on as that allows more people to own the brand. Mukherjee is one of the most copied designers in the country. "Today, all top jewellers in the country are copying my jewellery. It happened with my clothes, it's now happening with my jewellery, so I know we are on the right track," he says. The same is the case for his accessories. "You go into a copy market and you see LV, Calvin Klein, Gucci and Sabyasachi. I am flattered because that means we have done something right," he chuckles.

Over the years he has entered into some remarkable collaborations, establishing his brand further. In 2015, he announced his first global one with Christian Louboutin with a collection of limited-edition shoes and handbags, showcasing Sabyasachi's hallmark embroidery and craft, with Louboutin's iconic red sole. He also launched the Sabyasachi for Nilaya collection in collaboration with Asian Paints. Other collaborations have included Pottery Barn, H&M, L'Oréal, Strabucks, Thomas Goode, etc. He says he is open to more collaborations but only with brands that are the best in their field and those that allow him to "tell the Indian

58 | Fashion designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee recently made a guest appearance on Season 2 of Amazon Prime Video's popular series *Made in Heaven*

